The 6:15

FRIDAY · OCTOBER 23, 2026 NO. 29

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Today	World Series Game 1, Rays at Brewers, American Family Field, Milwaukee (8p ET, Fox); Knicks at Boston Celtics.
Sat 10/24	Northwestern (No. 24 AP, 5-1) hosts Rutgers, Ryan Field, noon ET.
Tue-Wed 10/27-28	FOMC meets. Cut odds still thin, ~20%-24% across prediction markets, little changed from issue No. 28's 15%-24%.
Wed 10/28	GE Vernova reports before the open — confirmed on multiple earnings trackers, though not independently on Nasdaq's or CNBC's own calendar. Microsoft and Alphabet also expected to report around this date **(not verified this run)**.
Thu 10/29	PCE (Sept. data) and the Q3 GDP advance estimate, both 8:30a ET. Amazon also expected to report **(not verified this run)**.
Sun 11/1	OPEC+ meets.
Tue 11/3	Midterm elections.

Coca-Cola and Boeing remain dated Oct. 27 on a UK-brokerage tracker (forex.com); Meta's report date is unconfirmed; none of the four verified against Nasdaq's or CNBC's own calendar this run — **not verified this run**. No frontier-AI release, rocket launch or VC mega-round cleared verification this run — eighth straight issue skipping that sub-bullet.

METRICS · ~6:05-6:20A ET UNLESS NOTED; NO ICE/NYMEX SETTLE YET PRE-NY-OPEN

Oil	Brent $109.67 (+0.93%, Yahoo BZ=F, 6:06a) / $113.72-$114.29 (+1.36%/+1.74%, straits.live, ~6:11-6:17a) **— a ~$4 gap, the widest split this brief has flagged between the two feeds**. WTI $101.08 (+1.62%, Yahoo CL=F Dec., 6:07a); spread ~$8.59 on the Yahoo basis (straits.live does not publish a WTI print).

Rates/$	2Y 4.65% / 10Y 4.96% / 30Y 5.29% (Treasury.gov, Thu. 10/22 close) — all down 13-16bp from Tue.'s close despite Thursday's stronger-than-expected jobless claims; DXY 101.70 (+0.09%, 6:07a). Real-time ticks this morning (investing.com, ~6:20a, secondary) have yields creeping back up: 2Y 4.671%, 10Y 4.978%, 30Y 5.300%.
Equities/vol	S&P futures (ES, Dec.) 7,689.00 (-0.20%); Nasdaq 100 futures (NQ, Dec.) 29,133.00 (-0.03%), both ~6:07a — a much smaller move than Thursday's -1.03%/-1.74%; VIX 19.67 (+3.36%, 6:01a), also calmer than Thursday's +10.91%.
Gold/gas	Gold (Dec.) $4,038.50 (-0.54%, 6:07a) — extending Thursday's drop **(still falling on a nominally risk-off morning, unreconciled)**. AAA national retail gas $4.2926/gal today, up from $4.2701 on 10/21 — a second straight daily rise.
Asia (close)	Nikkei 225 62,693.16 (-0.34%); Hang Seng 23,093.37 (+0.69%); Shanghai Composite 3,690.48 (+0.89%) — a sharp turnaround from Thursday's broad rout (-2.40%/-3.03%/-1.48%).
Europe (mid-session)	FTSE 100 10,661.82 (-0.59%); DAX 25,149.24 (-0.88%); CAC 40 7,750.53 (-0.78%), all ~6:05a ET / ~11:05a-12:05p local — modestly lower, not routed.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Status	Closed to commercial shipping, straits.live, Day 236 **(single-sourced framing, continuity)**.
Transits	Still 4 vessels on Oct. 18 (IMF PortWatch) vs. 85/day baseline — the same reading carried since issue No. 27, now five days stale.
Strikes, 24h (claimed)	No new Iranian claim overnight; Thursday's seven-vessel claim stands uncorroborated by any independent monitor, and President Trump publicly called it fabricated — see Lead **[NEW]**.
Dark tankers	103 of 190 screened went AIS-dark, 24h (54.2%) vs. a 7-day average of 99.6 — up from issue No. 28's 51.7%/98.5 **[DEVELOPING]**. VLCC war-risk

	premium still ~32x pre-crisis, now dated to an Oct. 7 estimate — three weeks stale, background only.
Indices	Crisis Pressure 88±7 (Extreme, essentially flat); Escalation Forecast 62±11 (High, +1) — the second straight one-point rise, both straits.live.
Market odds	Polymarket, reported for the first time across three horizons: normal transit by Oct. 31 <1% (unchanged); by Nov. 30, 6%; by Dec. 31, 12% **[NEW, single-sourced]**.

Methodology: PortWatch (lagged, AIS-only strait transit count), UKMTO (incident reports over a wider maritime area) and straits.live's own AIS snapshot measure different populations over different windows — never averaged or differenced here. See Lead for the separate dispute over Kpler/Vortexa flow estimates.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Season over — eliminated Oct. 7, swept 3-0 by Tampa Bay.
Knicks	0-1; at Boston Celtics tonight, Fri. 10/23 — no game since issue No. 28.
Northwestern	5-1, now AP No. 24; hosts Rutgers Sat. 10/24.

LEAD

HORMUZ / NARRATIVE & NUMBERS

Trump calls Iran's tanker claims fabricated for the midterms; markets claw back most of Thursday's panic even as the numbers underneath still don't agree

President Trump used Truth Social on Thursday to directly reject Iran's claim that its forces struck seven tankers in the Gulf in the prior 24 hours, writing that Tehran is fabricating hits and mine strikes to drive up oil prices ahead of next month's midterm elections, and asserting that more oil is moving through the Strait of Hormuz than ever before. [fact, NEW] He did not offer a government figure of his own to support that claim; the IRGC's

wider-response threat against US bases in the region, issued the same day, has not been retracted or addressed in his statements. [fact/flag, NEW] Iran's own account is unchanged from issue No. 28 and remains uncorroborated by any independent monitor — no vessel names, flags or casualties have been supplied for any of the seven. [fact, continuity]

The dispute exposed a flow-data fight that was already unresolved before Trump's post. IMF PortWatch's AIS-only count still shows just 4 vessels transiting the strait on Oct. 18 against an 85-per-day baseline — a 95% shortfall, and the same reading this brief has now carried for five days. [fact, continuity] Yet the Wall Street Journal, citing tanker tracker Kpler, has reported Iranian crude loadings averaging roughly 2.1 million barrels a day over a recent six-day window, above the roughly 2.0 million a day Iran was loading in February, even as other Gulf producers' shipments fell — the data point the administration appears to be leaning on. [fact, NEW] Separately, Vortexa put total product flows through the strait at 65%-70% of pre-war levels as of late September, and Kpler's own broader tally of Middle East exports fell to 12.8 million barrels a day in September from 18.8 million in February. [fact, NEW] None of the three trackers measures the same thing — Iran-specific loadings, all-product strait flow and regional export volume are different populations over different windows — and none supports a simple "flows are normal" framing; this brief is not reconciling them, consistent with the methodology rule applied to every Hormuz counter here. [read/flag]

Markets, for their part, spent Friday morning unwinding a meaningful share of Thursday's panic rather than extending it. Asia closed mixed rather than lower: the Hang Seng up 0.69% to

23,093.37 and the Shanghai Composite up 0.89% to 3,690.48, with only the Nikkei down, and only slightly, 0.34% to 62,693.16 — a sharp reversal from Thursday's broad 1.5%-3% rout. [fact] Europe was down only modestly at midday (FTSE -0.59%, DAX -0.88%, CAC -0.78%), and US index futures pointed to a far calmer open than Thursday's: S&P futures off just 0.20%, Nasdaq 100 futures essentially flat at -0.03%, with the VIX up 3.36% to 19.67 against Thursday's 10.91% spike. [fact] Oil itself split along the same lines as the flow-data dispute: Yahoo's BZ=F eased to $109.67, down from Thursday's $111.62 print even after a 0.93% gain intraday, while straits.live's own feed pushed the other way, to $113.72-$114.29 — a roughly $4 gap between the two sources this brief tracks, wider than any split flagged before. [fact/flag]

The bond market told a cleaner story Thursday, at least in the official close: Treasury's 2-, 10- and 30-year yields all fell 13-16 basis points from Tuesday (to 4.65%, 4.96% and 5.29%) even as the day's jobless-claims print came in stronger than expected — 194,000, near a 57-year low — which would ordinarily push yields up, not down. [fact, NEW] That combination points to a flight-to-quality bid driven by the Hormuz scare specifically, not by the labor data; real-time ticks this morning show yields creeping back toward Tuesday's levels (10Y 4.978%, 2Y 4.671%, 30Y 5.300%), the same partial-reversal pattern showing up in equities. [fact]

None of this resolves anything, and the asymmetry is worth naming plainly for a reader pricing risk rather than taking a side: if Iran's seven-vessel claim is substantially true, this is a wartime escalation that independent trackers simply haven't caught up to yet; if it is substantially fabricated, as the president now says on the record, Thursday's 2%-plus crude spike was priced on a false premise and

the move is a mispricing waiting to be unwound, not a signal about actual supply. [read] Friday morning's partial recovery across equities, bonds and (on the Yahoo feed) oil itself is consistent with markets quietly leaning toward the second interpretation without anyone saying so outright. [read] Trump's fabrication charge is now itself a data point the market has to price — it lowers the odds that officials in Washington treat this week's spike as a durable supply shock — but it does nothing to settle which tracker's flow estimate is right, and it lands eleven days before the FOMC meets with cut odds still thin (roughly 20%-24%) and eleven days before midterms in which 68% of Americans disapprove of the administration's handling of the economy, per Reuters/Ipsos. [read] Watch: whether any government, carrier, insurer or independent monitor corroborates or debunks any of Iran's seven claimed hits; whether PortWatch's transit count updates past its five-day-old Oct. 18 reading; whether the Brent split narrows or widens further through the NY settle; and whether Friday's partial market recovery holds into the weekend or proves to be a pause.

ECONOMICS

Thursday's initial jobless claims fell to 194,000 for the week ended Oct. 17, down 6,000 and below the roughly 200,000 consensus in a Bloomberg survey of economists — near a 57-year low, per Reuters and CNBC's framing. [fact, NEW] The four-week average fell to 197,750, the lowest since 2022, while continuing claims rose 25,000 to 1.728 million for the week ended Oct. 10. [fact, NEW] FOMC cut odds for next week's meeting remain thin, roughly 20%-24% across the prediction markets this brief tracks, little changed from issue No. 28's 15%-24% range; PCE for September and the Q3 GDP advance estimate both land Oct. 29, the morning after the decision

(continuity). [fact, continuity] Read: a labor market this resilient removes any domestic-data case for a near-term cut, leaving this week's oil shock — and the dispute over whether it is even a genuine supply event (Lead) — as the wildcard the committee has to look past or react to. [read]

A second supply-side data point lands before the Fed decision: OPEC+'s eight core members meet Nov. 1 to review policy after holding November output flat at 31.01 million barrels a day on Oct. 4, the second straight monthly pause following four consecutive increases. [fact, continuity] Reuters has reported Gulf producers pumping well below their own quotas even before this week's claims, with exports fluctuating at 60%-80% of normal levels because of war-related disruptions, and a UBS analyst quoted saying the market stays structurally tight regardless of whichever Hormuz flow estimate is believed. [fact, NEW] The war has also delayed the capacity review that would set 2027 quotas, per Reuters sourcing — a longer-dated complication this brief had not previously carried. [fact, NEW] No OPEC+ delegate has signaled a response to Thursday's claims or Friday's dispute over them. [fact/flag]

BUSINESS

Big Tech's earnings week is approaching: Microsoft and Alphabet are expected to report around Oct. 27-28 and Amazon around Oct. 29 on multiple earnings trackers, with Meta's date still unconfirmed anywhere this brief could check; none of the four is independently verified against Nasdaq's or CNBC's own calendar this run. [fact/flag, NEW] The stakes were set by issue No. 28's capex divergence — Tesla cutting 2026 guidance to roughly $20bn the same week Meta raised the low end of its own range. Standing

guidance from earlier this year, not updated this run: Microsoft at roughly $190bn for calendar 2026, with its CFO attributing part of the record budget to rising memory-chip prices; Alphabet raised to $195-205bn, after free cash flow turned negative in Q2 for the first time since its 2004 IPO; Meta's range most recently put at $130-145bn. [fact, continuity, dated to earlier-2026 guidance] Combined with Amazon, the four hyperscalers' 2026 capex is estimated near $700-750bn industry-wide; next week's reports are the next checkpoint for whether that spending holds or breaks against Tesla's more cautious read. [fact/read, continuity] GE Vernova's Oct. 28 pre-market report date is now corroborated across multiple earnings calendars, though still not against Nasdaq or CNBC directly; Coca-Cola and Boeing remain dated Oct. 27 on a UK-brokerage tracker only — **not verified this run** for either. [fact/flag]

TECHNOLOGY

No frontier-model release, rocket launch or VC mega-round cleared this run's verification bar — the eighth consecutive issue without one. [continuity] The capex-divergence story flagged in issue No. 28 now has a near-term resolution date: next week's Big Tech earnings (Business, above) will show whether hyperscaler spending plans are holding at a combined ~$700-750bn for 2026 or bending toward Tesla's more cautious read. [read, continuity] Nothing else moved on the technology beat overnight that isn't already captured in the Hormuz-driven market moves in the Lead.

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the fabrication dispute and the flow-data fight (Lead), the counters this brief tracks moved only at the margins. Dark tankers: 103 of 190 screened vessels went AIS-dark in the past 24 hours (54.2%) against a 7-day average of 99.6 — up from issue No. 28's 77 of 149 (51.7%)/98.5, a continuing drift rather than a jump. [fact, DEVELOPING] Crisis Pressure holds at 88±7 (Extreme, essentially flat vs. 88±8); the Escalation Forecast ticked up again to 62±11 (High, +1) — the second straight one-point rise, both straits.live, methodology not independently checked. [fact, continuity] Polymarket's odds on a return to normal transit are reported for the first time across three horizons rather than one: under 1% by Oct. 31 (unchanged), 6% by Nov. 30, 12% by Dec. 31 — all single-sourced to straits.live's aggregation and all still pricing a long crisis regardless of this week's rhetoric. [fact, NEW, single-sourced] The VLCC war-risk premium this brief has carried at roughly 32x pre-crisis is now dated to an Oct. 7 estimate — three weeks stale — and should be read as background, not a current price. [fact/flag] Tehran's open-market exchange rate, tracked here for the first time in issue No. 28, moved to 272,825 toman per dollar (buy 271,450/sell 274,200), up 0.40% on the day and 3.0% on the week — continuing currency pressure that predates and is separate from Thursday's tanker dispute. [fact, DEVELOPING] UKMTO has issued no new Hormuz-specific advisory since the Tuesday Al Faw incident carried in issue No. 28; its most recent item, an interaction with military forces roughly 121 nautical miles east of Duqm, Oman on Oct. 19, lies outside the strait itself and is not being added to the strike tally. [fact, continuity] Diplomatically, nothing has moved: Araghchi's

seven-day reopening offer remains unanswered in anything dated this month. [continuity]

SPORTS

Yankees	Season over; eliminated Oct. 7, swept 3-0 by Tampa Bay in the ALDS.
Knicks	0-1; at Boston Celtics tonight, Fri. 10/23 — tip not yet played at press time.
Northwestern	5-1, now AP No. 24; hosts Rutgers (2-4) Sat. 10/24, noon ET, Ryan Field — a 16.5-point favorite per the AP.
World Series	Game 1 tonight, Rays at Brewers, Milwaukee, 8p ET, Fox — Brewers favored (-162 to -164 ML); Jacob Misiorowski probable for Milwaukee, Drew Rasmussen for Tampa Bay. Both clubs opened the season as long shots (Tampa Bay 80-1, Milwaukee 35-1, DraftKings); a Rays title would tie the 1991 Twins as the longest preseason underdog to win it.

Continuity. Politics is cut this issue — Reuters/Ipsos's newest wave (Oct. 19-20) shows Trump approval at 31%, against 32% in the wave carried in issues No. 27-28; that is within normal poll-to-poll noise, not a move, so this brief isn't re-adjectiving a stale read. Geopolitics (Russia-Ukraine) stays cut — nothing dated past the single-sourced Oct. 11 energy-truce claim carried previously.

Unverified figures are marked in red: the ~$4 Brent split between Yahoo and straits.live, the widest yet; Iran's seven-vessel claim, now disputed by President Trump as fabricated; Microsoft/Alphabet/Amazon/Meta and Coca-Cola/Boeing earnings dates; gold continuing to fall on a nominally risk-off morning, still unreconciled; Tehran's toman rate (single-sourced). Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.